

» In contrast, the method of honoring Tezcatlipoca consisted of choosing the most handsome and brave prisoner of war to be an incarnation of this complex god, who is often considered to be the rival of Quetzalcoatl. After a year of being pampered, the prisoner's last month was spent in the company of four "goddesses" who met his every desire. He would then be sacrificed.

The Incas

In South America, the Incas used both conquest and peaceful assimilation to expand their empire, until it was the largest in pre-Columbian America. Expansion was remarkably rapid, only starting in earnest in the reign of Pachacuti, which began around 1438. He and his son, Tupac Inca, created a huge federal system consisting of four provinces, each overseen by an Inca governor. Following each new conquest, magnificent roads, many of them paved, were built to link it to the capital Cuzco



Lost city of the Incas

Machu Picchu is the best preserved of the known Inca settlements. Abandoned in the 16th century, it is a fine example of Inca architecture and planning. High-quality building work and numerous shrines suggest that the site had religious importance.

and the rest of the empire. The Incas had no horses, nor had they discovered the wheel; messages were carried by relays of runners, while llamas served as pack animals. Their superior organization enabled them to absorb many existing states, the largest being Chimor on the coast of northern Peru, home to the influential Chimú culture. By Tupac Inca's death in 1493, Inca rule reached north to Quito in Ecuador.

Like other American cultures, the Incas built temples devoted to their gods, of whom there were many—the sun god, Inti, being most important. Their worship included divination, and animal and human sacrifice. Although fairly rare, human sacrifice normally involved children taken from villages around the empire.

INVENTION

QUIPU

The Incas used collections of knotted colored threads, called *quipu*, to record information. Spun from llama and alpaca hair, there might be just a few threads in a *quipu*, or hundreds or even thousands. Like decimalization, the system is based on the number 10. *Quipucamayocs*—accountants in Inca society—would use the *quipu* to perform simple mathematics, calculate taxes, and keep records of labor or livestock, for example. They were also used for censuses and for tax accounting, and to track events and time. Inca historians used them to tell the Spanish conquistadors their history, although it is unknown whether the strings simply recorded important numbers or contained the history itself.



Culture and architecture

Elaborate architecture is one of the most important legacies of Inca civilization. The complex stone temples built by the Incas used a mortarless construction process that had been developed between 300 BCE and 300 CE by the Pucara peoples in lands to the south of Cuzco, around Lake Titicaca. Each stone was carved to slot exactly into the one below it. Final adjustments were made by lowering the rock onto the one below, raising it again, and chipping away any sections on the lower rock where marks in the dust indicated that the fit was not perfect. This attention to detail meant that buildings constructed by this method were extremely stable.

Machu Picchu

Apart from Cuzco itself, much of which was damaged by the Spanish conquistadors (see AFTER), the most complete remaining example of the Inca's careful planning and building techniques is Machu Picchu. Situated 40 miles (70 km) northwest of Cuzco, it is

Chimú pottery

The Chimú, one of the many peoples whose lands fell to the Incas in the 15th century, produced strikingly sculpted pottery figures. Their civilization owed much to the earlier Moche (see p.140).



Temple of Kukulcán

Dominating the center of Chichén Itzá is the Temple of Kukulcán (Quetzalcoatl, the plumed serpent of the Aztecs and Toltecs). At the spring and fall equinoxes, the sun creates undulating patterns of triangles of light on the temple stairway. These link with the massive carvings of snakes' heads at the foot of the stairs, suggesting a giant serpent zigzagging down the face of the pyramid.

thought that Machu Picchu is a relatively recent construction, dating perhaps from the mid-15th century. The quality of the stonework, the high altitude of its position, and the many shrines that have been identified among its ruins seem to indicate that this settlement was much more important than a mere rural village. It has been suggested that Machu Picchu was one of a number of royal estates built by Pachacuti. According to Spanish chroniclers, these settlements were used as country estates when the Inca ruler traveled out of Cuzco.

Mississippian culture

Although not geographically close to the Mesoamerican civilizations of the Maya and the Aztecs, the Mississippians had many things in common with their cultures, most notably the construction of monumental pyramids. The arrival of the Spanish also spelled the end of their civilization, but for different reasons (see AFTER).

The Mississippian culture developed from c. 800 CE in the valley

of the Mississippi River and spread to much of central, eastern, and southeastern North America. The Mississippian peoples lived in a highly structured society with close ties to the land: they relied on corn as their staple food. Key settlements were created at Spiro Mounds in eastern Oklahoma, Moundville in Alabama, and Etowah Mounds in northern Georgia; the most elaborate center was based at Cahokia Mounds in Collinsville, Illinois.

Cahokia was inhabited from the 7th to the 14th centuries and at its peak had around 30,000 inhabitants. The inhabitants made flat-topped mounds on which they built houses, burial buildings, and temples. More than 120 mounds were built, and many were enlarged several times.

